

Kebabs Around the World

Some sources claim that a shortage of cooking fuel led to the development and rapid spread of the quick-cooking kebab. Today, kebabs are found across the eastern Mediterranean and the Middle East, stretching as far as Central and South Asia.

TURKEY

Meşhur Köfteci Ali Usta inexpensive

Yalı Caddesi, Tekirdağ; +90 282 261 1621

This popular kebab house has been serving up the regional specialty, *bugu kebabı*, along with the town's celebrated *Tekirdağ köftesi* spicy meatballs, in its promenade-facing restaurant since 1966. The food is authentic and competitively priced.

Dibek moderate

Hakkı Paşa Meydanı 1, Göreme;
www.dibektraditionalcook.com

The Cappadocian town of Göreme is famous for its *köfte* and *testi kebab*, and Dibek serves both along with other enticing Cappadocian dishes in a cozy, atmospheric 16th-century building.

Kebabçı İskender expensive

Ünlü Caddesi 7, Bursa; +90 224 221 4615

Founded in 1867, and something of an institution, this kebab house takes its name from the inventor of the *İskender* kebab, from whom the current owners claim descent. It serves the *İskender* along with Bursa's other famous dish, the *inegöl köftesi*.

IRAN

Akin to a kind of national dish, kebabs dominate most Iranian menus. They are served principally in the form of shish kebabs, on bread or with steamed rice, or as *kubide* (like *köfte*). Grilled tomatoes, sliced raw onion, and sumac spice are typical accompaniments.

Ferdosi Sonnati inexpensive

Ferdosi St., Tehran; +98 21 6671 4503

With a firm local following, the Ferdosi prepares fresh, seasonal, and carefully cooked classic Persian dishes (including kebabs) at excellent prices. Try the homemade *dugh*, a refreshing sour yogurt drink that's the traditional kebab accompaniment.

The Khayyam Traditional Restaurant moderate

Khayyam St., Tehran; +98 21 5580 0760

After a trip around the Tehran bazaar, there's no better escape than to the Khayyam, lying on the bazaar's western periphery. Set in an early 18th-century building, this East-Asian-style oasis is atmospheric, cool, and relaxed and offers classic Iranian food and drink from a menu that's more eclectic than most in Tehran (see also pp178–9).

Sofre Khane Sonnati Sangalag moderate

Park-e Shahr, Tehran; +98 21 6673 1075

Conveniently situated close to Tehran's Golestan Palace and city museums, the Sangalag makes a perfect pit stop while sightseeing. Set in the Park-e Shahr, it's tranquil and verdant and serves good home-prepared traditional fare, including kebabs and salads, at decent prices.

INDIA

Despite the significant rate of vegetarianism in India, meat kebabs (mainly chicken, lamb, and sometimes goat) have long featured in Indian cuisine, particularly in tandoori cooking and the meat-dominated Mughlai cuisine of northern India. The famous Arab traveler Ibn Battuta recorded a description of kebabs when he visited India in the 14th century.

Karim's inexpensive

168/2 Jha House Basti, Nizamuddin West, Delhi

Karim's may seem simple and unremarkable, but it's been serving first-rate Mughlai cuisine for nearly a century and is much loved locally for its succulent and subtly spiced kebabs. It's located down a side street opposite the south gate of the Jama Masjid (Great Mosque). Try the *burrah* (marinated lamb kebab) and finish with a creamy *firni* – a sweet rice pudding with cardamom, almonds, and pistachios.

Tunday Kababi moderate

Aminabad Rd., Lucknow; +91 522 552 4046

Although Lucknow is famous for its sophisticated Mughlai cuisine and its variety and quality of kebabs, the Tunday has established a near-iconic status both at home and abroad. Its mutton kebab, made of ground or minced lamb, is legendary. The *kathi kebab*, cooked on skewers in a tandoor oven, is also great.

